

Problems aplenty: The scheduling issue, while not a roadblock, continues to be a thorn for HIL, leading to several overseas stars like Christopher Ruhr (extreme left) pulling out. GETTY IMAGES

"A lot of the guys who have to be at home for Christmas, once they realised that the dates coincide with that, said they need to be with their families. I think that's where issues came from. Hats off to the guys who are coming to India despite Christmas. They're missing out on a big festival [Christmas] to be here. So, my respect for them as well," said Singhania, whose team will also miss the services of Spain's Alvaro Iglesias.

On the timing of the league, Sai Prakash Komireddi, CEO of Hyderabad Toofans, said, "The league will learn lessons from this. That's the way it starts. And there are bound to be a few problems when you start a league."

While the 2024 auction brought riches to Indian talents, it wasn't as lucrative for the overseas stars. Olympic gold medallist and World Cup winner Boon, signed for Team Gonasika for Rs. 27 lakh (€30,300), much less than 20-year-old Arajjeet Singh Hundal (Rs. 42 lakh), an Indian junior team player. Germany's Ruhr, one of the top buys in the 2016 auction for Rs. 63 lakh, had his final bid set at Rs. 18 lakh this year.

Pirmin Blaak, the Netherlands' shootout hero in the Paris Olympics final, said he earned more in the 2013 edition of the HIL. "Back then, the pay was better," Blaak told *RTL Nederland* after the auction. Blaak, picked up by Bengal Tigers for Rs. 25 lakh, two lakh less than his 2013 price, will not feature in this edition.

The 2024 auction format, in which the Indian Paris Olympic men's team went under the hammer first, with a salary cap of Rs. 4 crore for each team, meant some foreign players were undervalued.

"In the last edition of HIL, overseas players were paid more than the Indians. This time, however, the tables have turned, and it seems a few international stars may not



entirely agree with the shift. What they fail to grasp is that Harmanpreet Singh isn't just one of the world's best drag-flickers — he's a brand in his own right. Everyone knows him as our beloved 'Sarpanch Sahab', and that star power is precisely why franchises kept bidding for him, even with a limited purse of just ₹4 crore," said Bhola Nath.

Only Gonzalo Peillat (Rs. 69 lakh), Jip Janssen (Rs. 55 lakh), and Jeremy Hayward (Rs. 42 lakh) were among the overseas players bought for over Rs. 40 lakh, largely due to the demand for penalty corner experts.

The HI secretary general also ensured tight measures are in place in the event of non-payment issues. "In the rare event that a franchise is unable to fulfil these commitments within 45 days of the season's conclusion, the League reserves the right to temporarily suspend their participation until the dues are cleared. During this period, the franchise would also forego its share of the Central Rights Income. If payments remain outstanding

beyond 60 days, HIL may consider further action, including the possibility of terminating the agreement after providing due notice," said Bhola Nath.

Fight for second place

In an era of Indian sports where franchise competitions dominate mainstream sports, and with the Indian men's team's performances in successive Olympics, it was a no-brainer for corporates to give HIL another go.

"Cricket is right up there as the top sport in India. But next to cricket, looking at which sport is going to be second to cricket, that has to be hockey because it has the ingredients for it," said Toofans' Komireddi. The HIL window will mean fewer clashes with domestic competitions for TV ratings. The Pro Kabaddi League (PKL) wraps up on December 29, but there is the ISL, and the Indian men's cricket team has four white-ball matches scheduled during the business end of the HIL.

However, apart from the IPL, and